

deshosieedit

Travel Radio Australia and we're here on the Gold Coast at the Disaster and Emergency Management Conference which is held in Australia and New Zealand and I have the chair of the whole conference here. Now Des Hosie, it's a fantastic conference. I've been here for a couple of days and what a magnificent event for the emergency services people.

It absolutely is, thanks Geoff. Yes, we are very proud of the event. It's been running for a number of years now here in Queensland on the Gold Coast.

It's a broad ranging disaster emergency management conference. So we look at catering for people from right across the sector. So from the people that make a cup of tea and look after folk in an evacuation hall in a local community, right through to the chief executives of some of our major services and agencies.

So it's a very very wide group of people that come along. We have just on at the moment around about 600 delegates a year coming to our conference along with a trade display and this year we've got 40 trade displays here with some of the latest technology, resources, training, academic opportunities, you name it, water filtration, all sorts of things that are vital in the emergency space during disasters. Now Australia, we have all sorts of problems with bushfires, floods and represented here is the core people like the SES, the fire services, the bush people who fight the bushfires.

They find this conference so useful to help them prepare for the coming 12 months, correct? That's absolutely right but not only that, we have, as I said earlier, we have the people that support them. So the councils, the shires, the emergency management agencies, the people that work in incident management teams and behind the scenes and state centres that support response and the recovery from these incredible events. And with the increasing frequency of these events, the increasing complexity of these events and the challenges in getting more volunteers especially to be involved, these are some of the things that we look at at the conference and get perspectives and encourage the conversation on how we can grow as a sector right across.

To that end, as I mentioned earlier, it is an Australian New Zealand conference so we have quite a few Kiwis come over for it but also we've got a great following from our Pacific neighbours that are coming from Fiji, Samoa, Tonga, Papua New Guinea. This year we've got exhibitors and presenters and delegates from the United States, from the United Kingdom, from South Africa, from Norway and other parts of Europe. So we've got a very wide range of people here that come and they share their experiences and knowledge which then grows the experience and knowledge in the sector so we can take it back to our agencies, to our local areas and we can improve our response and recovery to these significant events that are occurring.

And the events are getting bigger every year. We only have to look at the European summer of 2026. Unbelievable events in France and things are getting worse.

Preparedness is so important for the Australian people and New Zealand people. Yes, it absolutely is. And to that end, you know, we are seeing Greece, Spain, France, Scotland.

Who would have thought the highlands of Scotland would catch fire? We have just sent a combined ANZAC force, Australia and New Zealand firefighters and incident managers, to support the United States. I think we sent 70 over there last week and there'll be more deployments. They go over for about 21 days each and then they come back.

So all of this builds into what we already know, as you mentioned, we're coming into quite a strong El Nino summer for us here in the southern hemisphere. And so there's a very strong focus on how we're going to be prepared for that. And as an aside, one of the things we offered our delegates was a tour of the Gold Coast Emergency Management Centre and how they've invested here in having a disaster ready centre to face some of the significant events that strike this part of Queensland.

It's state of the art, it's world class, but it shows how Australia is investing in trying to protect its communities. And just briefly about your background, Des, how did you get involved in all of this? Well, I'm a career firefighter. I've been a firefighter for more than four decades.

I currently work in Fire and Emergency New Zealand National Headquarters and I'm the lessons guy for New Zealand. And I look at what we do, how we can do it better, how we can do it safer, make things work better for our people that are on the front line. And I bring a strong operational lens to that.

So what we put out for them is stuff that is actually practical and useful. I came here in 2018 to give a presentation on what we were doing in New Zealand and I saw immediately the value of this conference and I joined the organising committee. I've been on the organising committee since then and I've been the conference lead now, this is my third year.

So for me, it's an incredibly valuable trip to come over here for this conference to meet like minded people, to be challenged, to be inspired, to have great discussions and to look at how we can improve our response and our support for our people right across the sector. As I said, from the people making the cup of tea in the hall through to the chief executive, we've got a message for all of them. People of Australia and New Zealand are really grateful to you and your teams here for helping them in times of preparedness for disaster and emergency.

There's Hosie from, he's the chair of the Disaster and Emergency Management Conference here on the Gold Coast. Thank you so much for being part of our program. It is my pleasure, Geoff.

Thank you very much.

